

The "Breather" Protocol: Managing Context in Large AI Builds

This guide outlines the "AI Strategy Factory" method for managing context windows. The core philosophy is "**Context Hygiene**": treating the context window as a pristine workspace that must be cleaned after every major task.

Phase 1: The Master Plan (The Anchor)

Before writing code, you must create an external "Anchor" file. This file persists across sessions so Claude never loses the big picture, even if you wipe its memory.

1. **Create `implementation_plan.md`**
 - Ask Claude to generate a comprehensive plan broken into strictly isolated phases (e.g., Phase 1: Core, Phase 2: Research, Phase 3: UI).
 - **Rule:** Each phase must have a clear "Definition of Done" (e.g., "All tests in tests/phase1/ pass").
2. **The Only Context You Need**
 - When you start a new session, your first prompt should *always* be: "Read `implementation_plan.md`. We are currently at [Start of Phase X]. Do not read files from previous phases unless necessary for imports."

Phase 2: The Build Sprint (The Messy Part)

During a phase, allow Claude to be messy. It can create temporary files, logs, and debug scripts.

- **Isolate the Mess:** Instruct Claude to put temporary work in a specific folder (e.g., `temp_work/` or `skills_double_check/`).
- **The "Double Check" Pattern:**
 - Before marking a phase as done, ask: *"Create a script to verify that Phase X is working correctly. Run it."*
 - *Example:* In the video, we created a `skills-double-check` folder to prove we could generate PPTX/DOCX files. Once confirmed, we knew the *capability* existed without needing the *history* of how we got there.

Phase 3: The "Breather" (The Reset)

This is the critical step to prevent the "lobotomy" effect. Do this **immediately** after a phase is verified working.

Step A: The Summary Handoff

Before closing the session, ask Claude to compress its current state.

- **Prompt:** *"Phase X is complete. Update implementation_plan.md to mark it as done. Then, write a brief summary in project_status.md of exactly what was built, any key architectural decisions made, and what files are critical for the next phase."*

Step B: The Purge (Context Cleaning)

Delete the artifacts that were only needed for *learning* or *testing*, but not for *running*.

- **Action:** Delete the temp_work/ folder, raw PDF downloads, or intermediate JSON dumps.
- **Why:** In the video, we deleted the folder of 50+ raw consulting PDFs once we had the condensed "TL;DR" markdown files. We swapped 200MB of PDF context for 50KB of Markdown context.

Step C: The Hard Reset

1. **Commit Code:** `git add . && git commit -m "Complete Phase X"`
2. **Kill Session:** Type `/exit` or close the terminal.
3. **Breathe:** Literally take a 5-minute break. Let the "digital dust" settle.

Phase 4: Resuming (The Fresh Start)

Open a new terminal. Your context window is now at 0%.

1. The Prime Prompt:

"I am starting a new session. Read implementation_plan.md and project_status.md. We are now starting **Phase Y**.

Context Rules:

1. You do NOT need to re-read the code from Phase X. Assume it works as documented.
2. Focus only on the files required for Phase Y.
3. Let's begin by creating the folder structure for Phase Y."

Summary Checklist

Stage	Action	Goal
Start	Create implementation_plan.md	Establish the source of truth outside of chat history.
Build	Isolate work in temp/ folders	Keep the "mess" contained.
Verify	Run a "Double Check"	specific proof that the

	script	code works (not just chat assurance).
Purge	Delete temp/ & raw data	Remove "training wheels" and source bloat.
Summarize	Update project_status.md	Create a high-density context file for the next session.
Reset	/exit and Restart	0% Context Usage. Fresh brain for the next problem.